

NEWS ANALYSIS

Near Election, Deep Turmoil Grips France

Finances and Far Right
Imperil Welfare State

By MARK LANDLER

PARIS — Striking public workers. Barricaded high schools. Blocked ports. Budget paralysis. Surging bond rates. Fears of a far-right takeover.

France suddenly finds itself engulfed by crisis — not a single spasm of unrest, but a cascade of disruption that is roiling city streets, trading floors and public offices across the country. France’s “rentrée,” or “return,” as the French call the back-to-school and back-to-work season, has been anything but orderly.

The causes of the chaos may appear disparate, but they can be traced to a common root: France’s two-decade-long struggle to fund its state, now exacerbated by high borrowing costs, surging fuel prices and political uncertainty, with jockeying underway to replace President Emmanuel Macron next spring.

French public finances, already fragile, continue to deteriorate, fanning fears in financial markets that France could be the next European country to tumble into a full-blown financial crisis. The fiscal jitters were amplified by recent polls that show the far-right candidate, Marine Le Pen, would beat all of her rivals in presidential elections that will be held next spring.

On Tuesday, teachers and other public workers rallied against proposed wage freezes as the government labors to pass a budget. They joined thousands of students who have blockaded schools to protest underfunding that has led to crumbling facilities.

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People gathered on Tuesday in Paris as part of nationwide protests over crumbling school facilities and a shortage of teachers.

Houthis’ Dash for the Red Sea Found Yemeni Forces in Disarray

This article is by Vivian Nereim, Saeed Al-Batati and Shuaib Almo-sawa.

RIYADH, Saudi Arabia — In the weeks before the Iran-backed Houthi militia fanned out along Yemen’s Red Sea coast, sending their foes into a frenzied retreat, a Yemeni government commander called for help.

It was obvious to the commander, Lt. Gen. Tareq Saleh, that the Houthis wanted to seize his territory in order to reach the Bab al-Mandab Strait, one of the most important waterways in the world.

According to three Yemeni officials, he tried to warn his powerful allies in Saudi Arabia and the United States. About 10 percent of global trade goes through the strait. Amid the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran, both countries had an interest in preventing an Iran-linked militia from winning a perch beside it.

Yet last month — when the Houthis did just that — no one was able, or willing, to stop them.

The militia’s stunning triumph

Yemeni government reclaim the territory it lost, with intelligence and targeting assistance from the U.S. military. On Tuesday, government-allied forces claimed to have made significant gains, besieging the Houthi fighters who held the strait.

It is unclear whether the Houthis’ advance will hold, or where they will stop if it does. The Saudi government has pledged to help the Yemeni government “eliminate” the Houthis. The last time they took up that mantle, a

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AVISHAG SHAAH-YASHUV FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Remembering Oct. 7 Twins Adjust to Freedom

Gali and Ziv Berman were taken hostage when their kibbutz was attacked three years ago. They were freed a year ago, but the horrors of that day still haunt them, and Israel. Page A6.

Music in Schools at Risk as Instrument Costs Soar

By SYDNEY EMBER

Jeff Lipscomb, a high school orchestra director in Kanawha County, W.Va., has been doing a lot of math.

For example, he has 12 cellists but only 10 cellos. If the school district gives him a total budget of \$500 to \$600 for the year, but one new cello costs more than \$1,000, what should Mr. Lipscomb do? What if he needs some new violins and violas, too?

“I’ve actually had to buy instruments out of my own pocket,” Mr.

Tariffs Strain Band and Orchestra Budgets

Lipscomb said from his classroom at South Charleston High School on the first Monday of the school year. “I just kind of have to.”

Like many music teachers, Mr. Lipscomb has become attuned to tight budgets. Lately, though, the cost of instruments has ballooned beyond his ability to make do.

Pandemic-era supply chain

snarls lifted prices for goods across the board. President Trump’s global tariffs further swelled the cost of foreign-made instruments. Then in August, the Trump administration proposed additional 25 percent tariffs on trumpets, tubas and other brass instruments, citing “national security threats” under a provision it has used to impose duties on foreign metals.

The consequences have reverberated across the country. Higher instrument prices are a

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Texas Pediatricians Pressured By Paxton in Anti-Vaccine Push

By CHRISTINA JEWETT

It was a bustling Monday morning at a little pediatrician’s office in central Texas. Children with rashes, fevers and runny noses cycled through exam rooms decorated with butterflies, planets and colorful maps. The doctor, who had been treating kids in the community for 20 years, was delighted when a woman she had cared for as a child came in with her newborn.

Until recently, she had planned to continue her practice for years to come. But this year, she has begun to reconsider amid the stress and legal costs of defending herself in a statewide investigation by

Ken Paxton, the attorney general of Texas and Republican candidate for the U.S. Senate, who has accused doctors, drug companies and insurers of conspiring to push parents into vaccinating children.

She agreed to be interviewed and allowed a reporter to visit her practice but asked to be identified by her middle name, Rachel, to protect her from retaliation.

In December, Dr. Rachel received a letter from the attorney general’s Consumer Protection Division demanding her vaccine purchase records over the past 10 years. “The division believes that

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Trying to Film Like Mamdani? Not All Mayors Can Pull It Off.

By JULIE BOSMAN

CHICAGO — Susana Mendoza, the Illinois state comptroller and a candidate for mayor of Chicago, was not going to let the crummy weather get in her way. She had videos to shoot.

Sheltered on a drizzly recent afternoon under the overhang of a building along the Chicago River, Ms. Mendoza, in a black suit, high heels and her signature updo, faced a cellphone held aloft by a staffer — then flubbed her line.

“I’m the only candidate for mayor with the financial management experience and backbone to manage this crisis,” she said confidently, pointing at the camera as

she walked. Tackle the crisis, an aide corrected. Ms. Mendoza clapped her hands, then jogged in reverse to try once more. “This is how it works,” she said cheerfully.

And this is how mayors and mayoral hopefuls are talking to constituents these days: with snappy, walk-and-talk, make-policy-personal videos that reach voters on TikTok or Instagram.

The videos’ growing popularity can be traced to New York City and Mayor Zohran Mamdani, a digital native who is widely seen as a master of the art. His campaign relied on viral posts to get

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Mayor Jacob Frey of Minneapolis filmed iffy court skills.

NATIONAL A11-19

A Milestone Within Reach?

Democrats are increasingly confident that they will have a record number of women, as many as 113, serving in the House next year. PAGE A12

Inmate Regains Consciousness

Christa Pike, who survived her execution in Tennessee, was “conscious and speaking,” her lawyers said. PAGE A16

SPORTS B6-9

The Bronx Blunderers

The Yankees’ error-filled effort put the team in a 2-0 hole in the best-of-five series against the Rays. PAGE B7



INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Peeking at a Robotic Future

A park in Seoul filled with robots was a glimpse at cutting-edge technology, complete with some theatrics. PAGE A4

U.S. Weapons to Target Cartels

MQ-9 Reaper drones, known for deadly strikes, have been shifted to South America, officials said. PAGE A8

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An Appetite for Buddhism

A cookbook from the acclaimed chef Eric Ripert calls for mindfulness and gratitude in the kitchen — lessons he learned from a South Korean nun. PAGE D1

Good Wine Under \$30

Inexpensive bottles are often disappointing. But California producers are now trying to change that. PAGE D4

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Behind the Battlefield

The release of the video game Gears of War: E-Day has come amid Xbox leadership changes and studio layoffs. PAGE C1

BUSINESS B1-5

Who’s Liable for Rogue A.I.?

Many think artificial intelligence companies should be held responsible for their runaway technology. But legal scholars say applying existing law could be messy. PAGE B1

Paramount Closes Warner Deal

After a legal battle, the two Hollywood giants have become one. But the new company is saddled with debt, and in a memo to employees, its leaders hinted at cost and job cuts. PAGE B1

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Thomas L. Friedman PAGE A20

OBITUARIES A22

Fallen Television Preacher

Jim Bakker, with his wife, Tammy Faye, built a juggernaut around the gospel of prosperity. Sexual and financial scandals were his ruin. He was 86.

